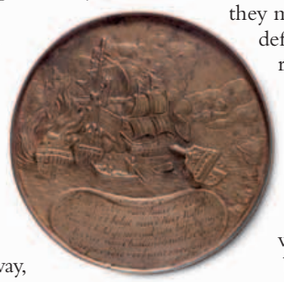
THE RAID ON THE MEDWAY

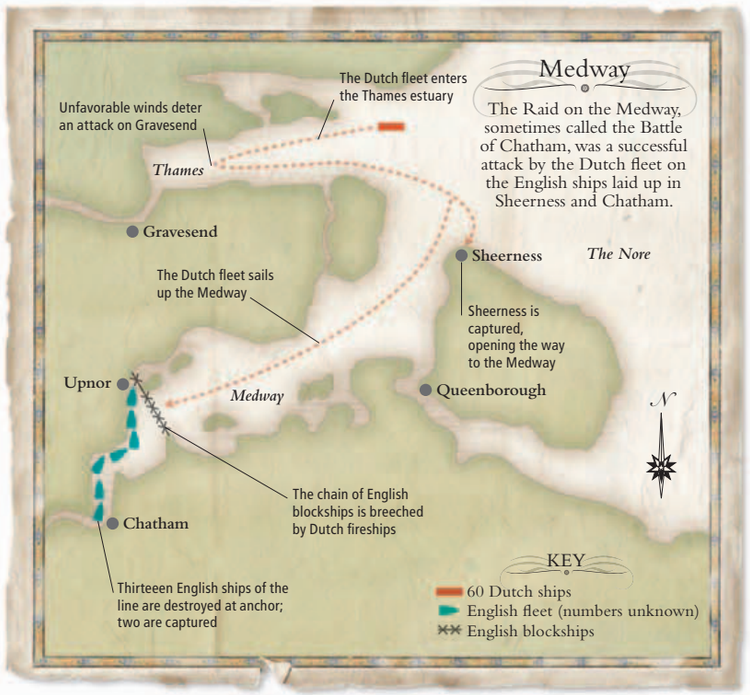
In the winter of 1666–67, with peace negotiations with the Dutch under way, King Charles and his advisers decided to keep the fleet laid up in dockyards when spring came. Meanwhile, the Dutch political leader Johan de Witt wanted to inflict a humiliating defeat on England that would enable him to dictate peace terms. He ordered an expedition to raid the Thames and the Medway, placing his brother Cornelis in charge to ensure bold aggressive action. The Dutch fleet appeared in the Thames estuary on June 7. Overcoming the objections of his cautious sea captains, Cornelis de Witt ordered his ships into the mouth of the Thames, where they failed to capture 20 merchantmen that took refuge in the direction of London. An attack on Sheerness three days later was more successful, Dutch marines capturing the poorly defended fort without difficulty.



Commemorative medal
This Dutch medal remembers the day "the ships of war... were attacked, burnt and sunk".

A clutch of English commanders, including George Monck (Duke of Albermarle), gathered at Chatham to organize the defense of the dockyards. Blockships were hastily sunk at various points in the Medway's navigable channels. The chain was defended by the frigate *Unity*, two captured Dutch merchantmen renamed *Matthias* and *Charles V*, and the ship of the line *Monmouth*. When the Dutch ships advanced into the Medway on 12 June they made short work of these defences. The *Unity*'s crew rapidly jumped ship, leaving their vessel to be taken. Fireships daringly sailed over the chain and set *Charles V* and *Matthias* ablaze. Dutch engineers dismantled the chain and worked to haul off the blockships, soon clearing the passage upriver.

The 80-gun first-rate *Royal Charles* had been left in an exposed position with a skeleton crew and was easily taken. Numerous other English vessels—including the great ships *Loyal London*, *Royal James*, and *Royal Oak*—were scuttled to prevent them too being captured. Half sunk, the three great ships were set on fire by the Dutch to complete the scene of destruction. Only *Monmouth* escaped. The Dutch took some casualties from the fire of shore batteries and guns in Upnor Castle. On June 14 they decided to withdraw, without having destroyed the dockyard stores. *Royal Charles* was towed back to the Netherlands, to be shown off to foreign visitors over the following years. Peace was soon made on terms highly favorable to the Dutch. But, rather like the United States after Pearl Harbor in 1941, England was soon able to rebuild its fleet and plot its revenge.



> A DREADFUL SPECTACLE AS EVER ENGLISHMAN SAW AND A DISHONOUR NEVER TO BE WIPED OFF.
>
> **JOHN EVELYN**, WRITER AND DIARIST, JUNE 1667

Destruction at Chatham
Some of the English navy's best ships were destroyed at Chatham, where they were laid up some 30 miles (48 km) east of London.



SECOND ANGLO-DUTCH WAR



THE RAID ON THE MEDWAY

Date	June 12, 1667
Location	Southeast England
Result	Dutch victory

COMBATANTS	
ENGLAND	**DUTCH REPUBLIC**
COMMANDERS	
George Monck	**Michiel de Ruyter, Cornelis de Witt**
FORCES	
Ships: Unknown	**Ships:** 60
LOSSES	
Ships: 15	**Ships:** 1 fireship